



THE REAL
DEPRESSION T_T

CHAPTER 3

WHEN THE LIGHTS WENT OUT

CRACK.

The transformer flashed again.

I looked up.

For a second, the entire road was illuminated by a strange blue-white glow.

Then—

CLICK.

Everything went dark.

The streetlights disappeared.

The traffic lights went black.

The shops in the distance went dark.

The headlights of the cars became the only source of light.

Even Arjun's precious RGB lights disappeared.

For the first time that night, Arjun stopped typing.

The CRT monitor flickered.

Once.

Twice.

Then the screen went completely black.

Arjun stared at it.

“No.”

He pressed a button.

Nothing.

He pressed it again.

Nothing.

He looked at the UPS.

Its little display was flashing an angry warning.

Arjun slowly stood up.

The entire crowd watched him.

Someone shouted:

“BRO, THE RGB DIED!”

Another person yelled:

“THIS IS THE WORST DAY OF HIS LIFE!”

Arjun ignored them.

He looked toward the transformer.

Then toward his cables.

Then back at his computer.

He grabbed a flashlight from underneath the wooden desk.

The police officer immediately stepped forward.

“Where are you going?”

“I’m going to find out what happened.”

“Stay away from the electrical equipment.”

Arjun stopped.

For once, he didn’t argue.

He simply nodded.

“Fine.”

He walked toward the transformer area while keeping away from the equipment.

I followed him for a few steps.

The rain had become heavier.

The road was almost completely dark now.

Behind us, dozens of cars were trapped in silence.

No music.

No horns.

No streetlights.

Just rain.

Tap.

Tap.

Tap.

Then someone in the traffic shouted:

“WAIT.”

Everyone turned.

A man pointed toward Arjun's computer.

The CRT had turned back on.

Nobody had touched it.

The screen was glowing faintly.

Green text began appearing.

One line.

Then another.

Then another.

Arjun froze.

“What?”

He ran back toward the platform.

The police officer followed.

I followed the police officer.

And suddenly everyone else followed me.

Within seconds, half the traffic jam had turned into an audience.

Arjun reached the computer.

The monitor displayed:

SYSTEM RECOVERING...

He stared at it.

Then the next message appeared.

POWER SOURCE: UNKNOWN

Arjun's expression changed.

“What does that mean?”

The screen flickered.

Another line appeared.

NETWORK CONNECTION: ACTIVE

Someone behind us whispered:

“Bro's computer has Wi-Fi during a blackout.”

Another person replied:

“Forget Wi-Fi. HIS COMPUTER HAS MORE LIFE THAN THE CITY.”

A driver rolled down his window.

“ARJUN!”

Arjun looked up.

“What?”

“YOUR COMPUTER IS HAUNTED!”

The crowd burst out laughing.

Arjun didn't laugh.

He was staring at the screen.

Something wasn't right.

He opened the case of the old computer and looked inside.

The components were ancient.

The monitor was ancient.

The entire setup looked like it belonged in a computer museum.

Yet the machine was running.

Without the normal power.

The police officer looked over his shoulder.

“Can you fix it?”

Arjun frowned.

“I don’t know.”

The officer looked surprised.

“You don’t know?”

“No.”

That answer made the entire crowd silent.

For the first time since I had seen him, Arjun looked genuinely confused.

Then the CRT suddenly displayed another message.

Everyone leaned forward.

Arjun immediately turned the monitor away.

“BACK UP!”

The crowd stepped backward.

“What does it say?” I asked.

Arjun didn’t answer.

The screen flickered again.

He stared at it.

Then slowly whispered:

“That’s not my code.”

Silence.

The rain continued falling.

The transformer in the distance made another strange sound.

CRACK.

The police officer reached for his radio.

“Everyone stay back.”

But before he could say anything else—

Every car in the traffic jam suddenly turned on its hazard lights at exactly the same time.

CLICK. CLICK. CLICK. CLICK. CLICK.

Hundreds of orange lights began blinking through the rain.

The entire road started glowing.

People started shouting.

Someone yelled:

“WHY DID EVERY CAR DO THAT?!”

Another person shouted:

“WHO PRESSED THE BUTTON?!”

Nobody had.

Then Arjun's RGB lights came back on.

Red.

Blue.

Green.

The crowd stared.

The police officer stared.

I stared.

Arjun stared.

The lights began cycling faster.

Red.

Blue.

Green.

Red.

Blue.

Green.

Someone shouted:

“THE RGB IS BACK!”

Another voice answered:

“WE'RE SAVED!”

Arjun slowly sat back down.

He looked at the monitor.

The screen was still showing the strange message.

He placed his hands on the keyboard.

And whispered:

“Okay.”

He took a breath.

“Let's find out what you are.”

I looked at the clock.

12:41 AM.

My grandmother was still waiting for me at home.

I was still stuck in traffic.

The city was still partially blacked out.

The police were still trying to understand what was happening.

And somehow...

I had completely forgotten about going home.

Because now I wanted to know the same thing Arjun did.

What was running on that computer?

